

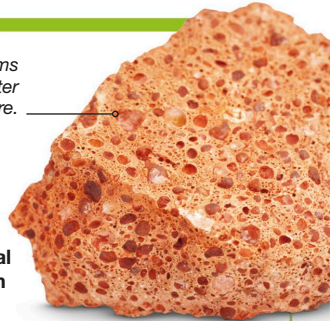
Soft metals

Most boron group metals, including indium, can be cut with a steel knife, so they are not tough enough for construction. Only aluminium is suitable for building structures. By contrast, boron – the sole non-metal – is one of the hardest elements of all.



Pure indium mould cast
in a laboratory

*Aluminium atoms
make up a quarter
of this ore.*



**Bauxite, a mineral
ore of aluminium**

Natural compounds

The elements in the boron group are never found pure in nature, despite not being very reactive. All of them, like members of some other groups, have to be purified from ores. Aluminium is a very common ingredient in minerals, while the other elements are considerably rarer.

Conducting metals

The metallic members of this group are all good conductors of electricity, especially aluminium. Because aluminium is more lightweight than other conducting metals, it is often used in overhead electricity cables. Semi-metallic boron, however, is a good insulator when pure and blocks electric currents.

Overhead cables
of aluminium

